

If all this sounds like an unexpected introduction to a luxury resort, it really is not. Taj's Kutir brand of resorts are envisaged to blend in their context—geographic and cultural—and Guras Kutir (named after Sikkim's state tree: the rhododendron) is an homage to the mountains and forests, local culture and local foods of the area. An easy 40-minute drive from Gangtok town, the hotel is built on 16 acres of forest and has left a majority of it undisturbed. The buildings lie low, the colours are subdued, the materials mostly stone and wood. All the rooms face the Kanchenjunga; anywhere you look, there is a carnival of green.

If the three things that matter most in a property are "location, location, location", Guras Kutir wins with ease. The land has been leased from a prince of the royal family; "Danny Denzongpa's brother-in-law!" local staff tell me. If at all you can see something other than forests, mountains and skies, it is two properties in the far distance that belong to—no surprises—Danny and Bhaichung Bhutia.

In the morning, the resort naturalist takes me on an interpretive hike in the forest, with the invisible presence of barking deer, wild boar, the Black Giant Squirrel, Giant Flying Squirrel and the endearing red panda. For an enchanting couple of hours, we roam amid Himalayan ferns, bamboo, chestnuts, Japanese sal, berries and trees with local names that I try out on my hesitant tongue: Lekchilauney (needlewood). We spot leopard droppings, chew on bitter but intensely fragrant mugwort leaves and watch the languid flight of steppe eagles. The silence shimmers and the air is fresh, moist and cold. I see a golden-bellied leafbird for the first time.



ECHOES OF KANCHENJUNGA Top, an exterior view of the Taj Guras Kutir; above, J Wellness Circle, the resort's spa

For most visitors, the flight to Bagdogra plus a five-hour drive to the resort can be worth it if they stay for three-four nights. (Better than the jacuzzi, Forest Essentials bath supplies, or butler service on picnics, the priceless luxury provided by the Taj is a stop, midway from Bagdogra, where you can have complimentary refreshments next to the Teesta and there is—that gold standard of luxury for a female traveller—a shining bathroom!)